

UNISYNC: UNLEASH THE CAMPUS SPIRIT – SHARING, SHAPING, SUSTAINING FOR A GREENER TOMORROW

Kajal Rai, Vikas Kumar
Department of MCA
GL Bajaj Institute of Technology and Management,
Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh, India.

Abstract— This paper presents UniSync, a web application platform designed to facilitate the buying, selling, and exchanging of used textbooks, stationery, and related materials among university students. The platform aims to promote sustainability and reduce waste on university campuses by encouraging the reuse and recycling of these items. Through an analysis of user behavior, satisfaction, and environmental impact, this study evaluates the effectiveness of UniSync in mitigating waste and fostering a more sustainable campus environment. Additionally, the paper explores UniSync's role in building a socially engaged student community and its potential for broader impact in promoting sustainability initiatives within universities.

Keywords— Sustainability, Peer-to-peer platform, Textbook exchange, Stationery exchange, Waste reduction, Student community

I. INTRODUCTION

In recent times, there has been a notable surge in the popularity of reusing, recycling, and peer-to-peer [1] sharing. People are increasingly conscious of their environmental footprint and are actively seeking ways to minimize waste and adopt more sustainable lifestyles. This shift is particularly evident in the market for second-hand goods market [2] such as home equipment and books, where there has been a significant increase in activity.

UniSync is a platform geared towards students that aims to foster sustainability and reduce waste [3] within university campuses. It focuses on facilitating the buying, selling, and exchanging of textbooks, stationery, and related materials among undergraduate students. By promoting the reuse and recycling of these items, UniSync strives to lessen their environmental impact while simultaneously enhancing accessibility and affordability for students.

What sets UniSync apart from other platforms is its commitment to being commission-free. This makes it a viable and sustainable option for students who may be on tight budgets. Through direct communication via the platform's chat application, users can negotiate prices and arrange exchanges

in a manner that is both convenient and cost-effective. With UniSync, students could contribute to waste reduction and sustainability efforts on their campuses, all while benefiting from a more economical and accessible means of acquiring study materials.

UniSync is an online platform that facilitates the buying, selling, and exchanging of textbooks, stationery, and related materials among undergraduate students, all without charging any commissions. The initiative was born out of the necessity to provide a sustainable and budget-friendly alternative for students facing financial constraints, while also aiming to curtail waste and encourage sustainability practices within university campuses.

A. Background –

The concept of UniSync stemmed from recognizing the hurdles students encounter while acquiring study materials. Existing platforms often impose steep fees, posing financial barriers for students. Moreover, students frequently discard or stockpile textbooks and hostel belongings post-graduation due to hefty management charges, leading to avoidable waste.

B. Motivation –

UniSync emerged from a vision to empower students with affordable, sustainable options for exchanging textbooks and materials. Escalating educational expenses, including the cost of textbooks, pose significant challenges for students. Many struggle to afford these essential resources, jeopardizing their educational pursuits and financial stability.

Simultaneously, the environmental impact of waste is undeniable. Students often dispose of or accumulate textbooks, stationery, and other hostel items post-graduation, exacerbating waste and pollution. UniSync addresses these issues.

As a user-friendly platform, UniSync facilitates direct peer-to-peer [6] transactions of textbooks, stationery, and materials, devoid of commission fees. This accessibility and affordability encourage sustainable practices by promoting material reuse and recycling.



By embracing UniSync, students not only save money but also diminish their environmental footprint. Each exchange on the platform mitigates landfill accumulation and pollution.

Thus, UniSync offers both economic and environmental benefits. UniSync fosters student connections and community building around resource exchange, enhancing academic support and collaboration.

In essence, UniSync revolutionizes textbook and material exchanges with its sustainable, cost-effective, and user-centric approach. By advocating reuse, recycling, and fee elimination, UniSync enhances resource accessibility, environmental consciousness, and community cohesion among students.

Furthermore, UniSync is adaptable to the evolving needs of students and universities. As educational requirements and course materials change over time, UniSync remains flexible in accommodating these shifts.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Introduction –

In recent years, the proliferation of the internet has transformed the landscape of commerce, giving rise to an array of online marketplaces commonly referred to as peer-to-peer (P2P) markets. These platforms have revolutionized the way individuals buy and sell goods and services, offering a diverse range of products and opportunities for interaction. From handmade crafts to freelance services, P2P markets have democratized commerce, enabling smaller players to compete with established corporations on a global scale.

At the heart of P2P markets lies a set of defining features that distinguish them from traditional retail environments. One such characteristic is their low barriers to entry for sellers, which allow virtually anyone with a product or service to participate in the marketplace. This inclusively has led to a surge in the number of sellers, resulting in a vast and diverse array of offerings for buyers to choose from. Additionally, P2P markets often facilitate spot transactions, eliminating the need for long-term contracts or formal employment arrangements. This flexibility empowers both buyers and sellers to engage with each other on a transactional basis, without being bound by rigid agreements.

Moreover, P2P markets leverage technology to enhance the matching of buyers and sellers, often employing dynamic pricing mechanisms to optimize efficiency. Through algorithms and data analysis, these platforms strive to connect users with relevant products and services, facilitating seamless transactions. Furthermore, the use of auction-based pricing mechanisms adds an element of competition, allowing sellers to experiment with pricing strategies and buyers to obtain goods and services at competitive rates.

One of the key aspects that sets P2P markets apart is their reliance on reputation and feedback mechanisms to maintain quality standards. Unlike traditional markets where participants may lack information about each other, P2P markets utilize feedback and ratings to establish

trustworthiness and reliability among users. This emphasis on transparency fosters trust within the platform, enabling users to make informed decisions and facilitating smoother transactions. Additionally, the use of reputation systems incentivizes sellers to uphold high standards of service, as positive feedback can bolster their credibility and attract more customers.

However, despite their numerous benefits, P2P markets have encountered regulatory challenges. Many of these platforms operate outside traditional regulatory frameworks, raising concerns about consumer protection and safety. Issues such as product quality, liability, and taxation have prompted regulatory scrutiny, with authorities seeking to strike a balance between fostering innovation and safeguarding consumer interests.

From an economic perspective, P2P markets offer valuable insights into market dynamics and resource allocation mechanisms. Platforms like eBay, Airbnb, and Uber provide opportunities for sellers to experiment with pricing strategies and marketing approaches, shedding light on consumer behavior and market trends. Furthermore, platforms such as Prosper and Kickstarter facilitate collective funding for loans and projects, while others like Upwork and TaskRabbit streamline the process of finding freelance work, offering valuable insights into labor markets and employment trends.

In conclusion, P2P markets have emerged as a significant force in the contemporary economy, reshaping the way individuals buy and sell goods and services. Characterized by low entry barriers, flexible transaction mechanisms, and technological advancements, these platforms have democratized commerce and empowered individuals to participate in the global marketplace. While they present regulatory challenges, P2P markets offer valuable insights into market dynamics and serve as catalysts for innovation and economic growth.

B. Matching buyers and sellers in peer-to-peer markets –

The proliferation of peer-to-peer (P2P) markets on the internet has introduced a myriad of challenges in efficiently connecting buyers and sellers. With a diverse array of offerings and individualized preferences within these platforms, ensuring optimal matches and fair pricing has become increasingly complex. The successful operation of these markets hinges on the effective collection and utilization of information to facilitate seamless transactions and foster mutually beneficial exchanges.

While auctions [7] are great for making sure things are sold efficiently and for a good price, but they're not always the best option. In certain P2P markets, such as Uber, the centralization of the matching process simplifies transactions by automatically assigning the nearest available service provider to the buyer. This streamlined approach benefits both parties by ensuring efficiency and cost-effectiveness. Conversely, platforms like eBay or Airbnb [4] present a different challenge, as buyers seek specific products or



accommodations. Here, the task lies in presenting a multitude of options in a user-friendly manner, facilitating easy navigation and selection.

The presentation of search results plays a critical role in influencing user behavior in online searches. The order in which search results are displayed significantly impacts user engagement, with top-ranked results garnering greater attention and click-through rates. This phenomenon holds particular relevance in internet advertising, raising questions about the incentive structure for websites and search engines to prioritize helpful results over potentially more profitable ones.

Researchers have delved into the search dynamics of P2P markets, analyzing data from platforms like eBay and Airbnb to understand user behavior and market complexities. Their findings suggest that presenting items ranked by price enhances the likelihood of buyers finding favorable deals, particularly for straightforward products with limited variations. However, in more intricate markets, such as rental accommodations, challenges arise even after identifying suitable options, as factors like seller rejections or simultaneous buyer inquiries may impede successful transactions [10].

Overall, the design of online P2P markets must strike a balance between facilitating seamless transactions and leveraging information effectively. Whether through centralized control or collaborative networks, the aim is to optimize user experience while ensuring efficient market functioning. The manner in which search results are presented is crucial for aiding users in finding desired items or services. As these markets evolve, addressing these challenges will be pivotal in enhancing market efficiency and user satisfaction [9].

C. The evaluation of pricing mechanisms in peer-to-peer markets –

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D. Peer-to-Peer seller Vs professional seller –

In the realm of online commerce, two primary categories of sellers exist: peer-to-peer (P2P) sellers and professional sellers, each with distinct advantages and drawbacks. The optimal choice between them hinges on individual needs and objectives.

Peer-to-peer selling entails a decentralized approach to e-commerce, wherein individuals directly sell goods and services to other individuals. Platforms such as Craigslist, Facebook Marketplace, and Unisync exemplify this model. P2P platforms typically boast low entry costs, rendering seller participation accessible to virtually anyone. Moreover, they offer considerable flexibility, enabling sellers to establish their own pricing structures and operate according to their schedules [12].

Conversely, professional selling represents a more structured approach to e-commerce, predominantly adopted by businesses. Professional sellers engage in online selling through dedicated marketplaces like Amazon, eBay, or Etsy. This avenue often demands significant investments in various resources, including inventory management, customer service, and marketing efforts. Nevertheless, professional sellers enjoy advantages such as access to a broader customer base, streamlined payment processing, and sophisticated analytics tools.

In summary, peer-to-peer selling and professional selling represent contrasting approaches to online commerce, each with its unique merits and challenges. While P2P selling offers accessibility and flexibility, professional selling provides access to a larger customer pool and advanced resources. The decision between them ultimately hinges on individual circumstances and goals.

III. METHODOLOGY

The project involved designing and developing a web application to help users manage their daily tasks and schedules. The web-app was designed to be user-friendly, with an intuitive interface and a range of features to help users organize their listings and prioritize their data. The project

team employed a user-centered design approach, involving potential users in the design process through interviews and surveys to ensure that the web-app met their needs and preferences.

Utilizing the Agile methodology “Fig. 1”, the development process was divided into multiple sprints or iterations. Each sprint focused on a distinct set of tasks and objectives, with frequent feedback and review sessions conducted to ensure the project advanced according to the established plan. Data collection occurred throughout the development process, including gathering user feedback on design mockups and prototypes, user testing sessions, and regular reviews of project progress and goals. User feedback was gathered through online surveys and in-person interviews.

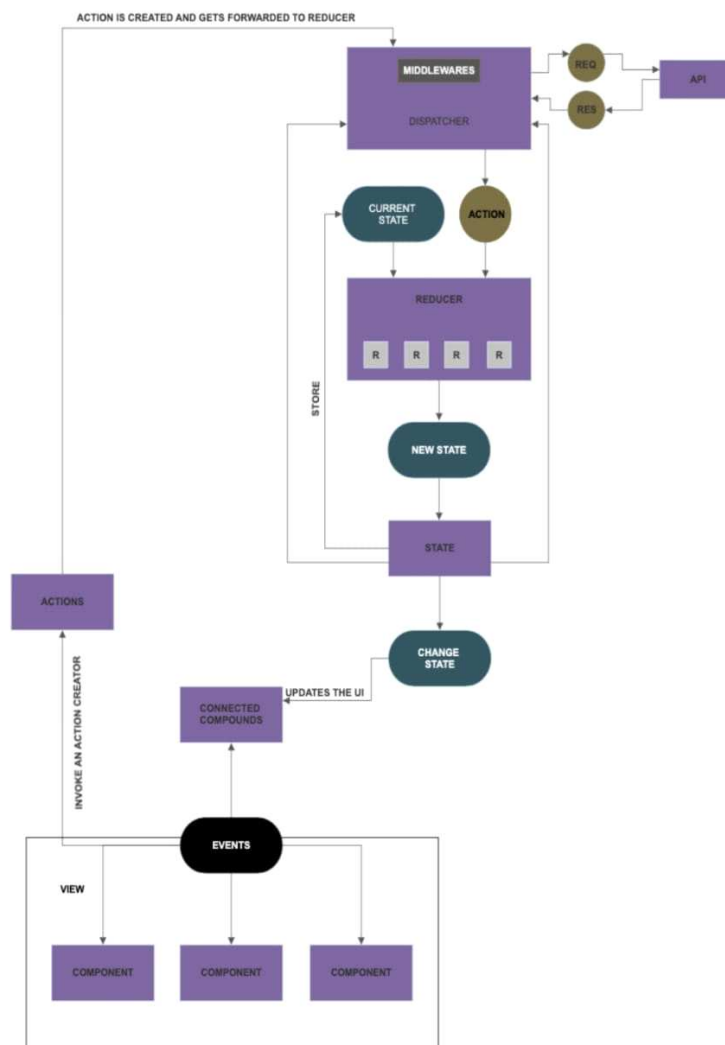


Fig. 1. Agile Methodology

The project encountered several limitations, such as the restricted scope of the web application, the small participant pool, and the focus on a single platform (web browsers). These constraints were acknowledged, and discussions were held regarding their potential influence on the overall applicability of the study findings. The project encompassed several pivotal steps, including crafting initial designs and prototypes, facilitating user testing sessions, and progressing through multiple development sprints following Agile methodology. Various tools and techniques were employed to manage the project, including project management software, collaborative platforms, and version control systems. Spanning several months, the project involved consistent progress meetings and feedback sessions to maintain alignment with objectives and ensure adherence to timelines. Incorporating a chat system and a chatbot “Fig. 2” into the UniSync project was a strategic enhancement aimed at enriching user experience and functionality. This addition expanded the project’s methodology by integrating real-time communication features alongside task and schedule management. Within the Agile framework, the development process adapted to accommodate the integration of the chat system and chatbot, allocating specific sprints to design, develop, and refine these components.

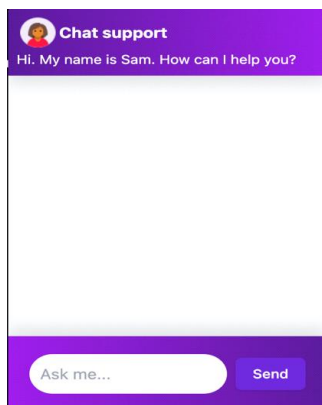


Fig. 1. Chatbot

Each sprint within the Agile methodology addressed distinct tasks related to the chat system and chatbot integration, including user interface design, backend development for chat functionality, natural language processing for the chatbot, and testing for usability and performance. Feedback loops were established to gather input from users on the effectiveness and usability of the chat features, ensuring they seamlessly integrated with the existing application and met user expectations.

The development of a chat system typically involves a combination of various programming languages and technologies “Fig. 3” to ensure seamless communication between users. JavaScript stands out as a cornerstone for web-based chat applications, enabling interactive and real-time messaging functionalities both on the client and server sides

through frameworks like Node.js. Alongside JavaScript, HTML and CSS are utilized to structure and style the chat interface, providing a visually appealing and user-friendly experience on web platforms. For server-side logic and database management, languages such as Python with frameworks like Django or Flask, Java for Android applications, Swift/Objective-C for iOS, and C# for Windows desktop applications are commonly employed. These languages facilitate robust backend development, ensuring efficient message handling, user authentication, and data storage using SQL-based database systems like MySQL or PostgreSQL. Additionally, WebSocket protocol plays a crucial role in enabling bidirectional communication between clients and servers, facilitating real-time updates and notifications within the chat system. JSON serves as a lightweight and versatile data interchange format, facilitating seamless communication between different components of the chat application. By leveraging this array of languages and technologies, developers can create feature-rich and responsive chat systems tailored to various platforms and user needs [13].



Fig. 3. Technologies for Chatbot

Data collection efforts extended to encompass feedback on the chat system and chatbot, obtained through user interactions, surveys, and usability testing sessions. These insights were vital for iterating and optimizing the chat features throughout the development process.

While expanding the project’s scope, the integration of the chat system and chatbot introduced additional complexities and considerations. These were addressed through collaborative discussions within the project team, adapting Agile methodologies to effectively manage and prioritize tasks related to the chat features alongside existing project objectives.

Overall, the incorporation of the chat system and chatbot into the UniSync project enhanced its functionality and utility, demonstrating the flexibility of Agile methodologies in accommodating evolving project requirements and technological advancements.

The project was conducted over a period of several months, with regular progress meetings and feedback sessions to ensure that the project was on track and meeting its goals.

The entire UniSync project, including its chat system, was deployed on Microsoft Azure to ensure scalability, reliability, and efficiency. Azure App Services facilitated easy deployment “Fig. 4” and CI/CD integration. Azure Web Pub

Sub handled real-time messaging, while Azure SQL Database and Blob Storage managed data and media files. Azure CDN enhanced performance by distributing content globally. Security was ensured with Azure Active Directory, and Azure Functions provided serverless computing for background

tasks. Monitoring and logging were managed via Azure Monitor and Application Insights, allowing proactive performance management. This comprehensive deployment leveraged Azure's robust infrastructure, ensuring a successful and high-performing application [14].

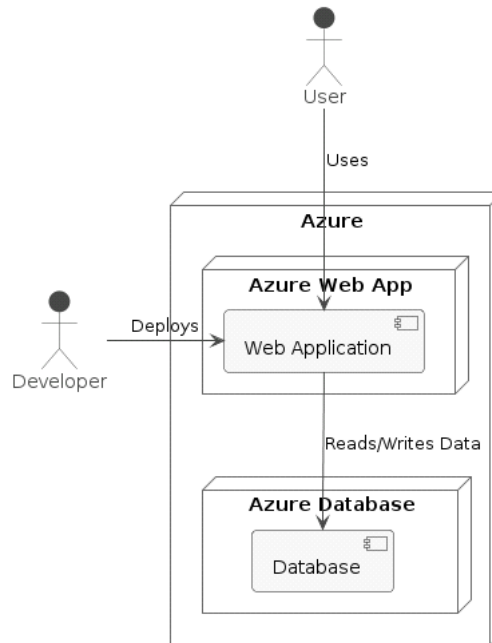


Fig. 4. Deployment

IV. RESULTS

A. User Behaviour and Satisfaction –

A survey encompassing students from 10 distinct universities unveiled limited utilization of peer-to-peer platforms for intra-university transactions. While a minority engaged with such platforms, the majority voiced contentment with their usage, attributing benefits like economical deals and ease of use. Additionally, the survey highlighted a notable enthusiasm among students, with 60% expressing interest in adopting UniSync. This keen interest stems from challenges encountered in procuring cost-effective textbooks and stationery, underscoring the anticipated demand for the platform upon its introduction. The findings suggest a latent market need for a comprehensive solution like UniSync, poised to address the specific requirements of university communities. By catering to these demands, UniSync stands to fill a vital niche in the student marketplace, offering a platform where both buyers and sellers can engage seamlessly, fostering a mutually beneficial environment.

B. Impact on Waste Reduction –

By facilitating the buying and selling of second-hand textbooks and stationery, UniSync has the potential to contribute to waste reduction on university campuses. Through the reuse of resources, the platform can help reduce

the production and consumption of new materials, thereby minimizing environmental impact. About 63.9% user's think that UniSync's would help in making the environment sustainable [15].

In Unisync, sustainability entails maintaining long-term operations while minimizing environmental impact, fostering social inclusion, and ensuring economic viability. This involves eco-friendly practices, equitable treatment of users, and sustainable business models to achieve a balanced approach benefiting both the platform and its stakeholders.

C. Affordability for Students --

UniSync addresses affordability "Fig. 5" by providing students access to second-hand textbooks and stationery at lower prices than new items. This initiative alleviates financial strain, especially for the 52.8% of students facing difficulties purchasing textbooks for their academics. By offering cost-effective alternatives, UniSync aims to enhance accessibility to essential course materials, supporting academic success. This approach not only aids students in managing their expenses but also fosters a sustainable model by promoting the reuse of resources, aligning with the platform's commitment to affordability and environmental consciousness.

Have you ever struggled to find affordable textbooks and stationary for your courses?

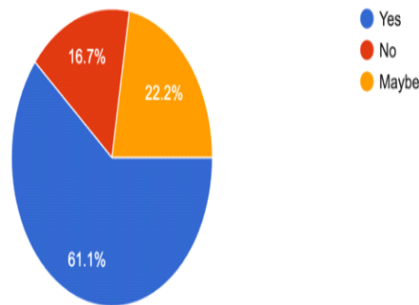


Fig. 5. Affordability Issue

How important is sustainability to you when purchasing course materials ?

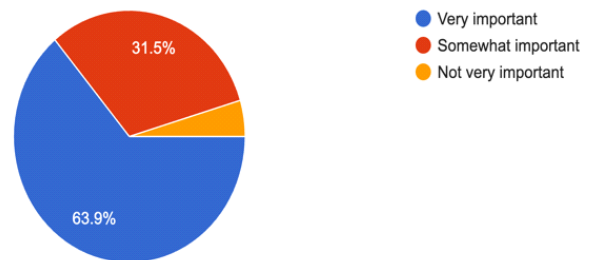


Fig. 6. Sustainability Survey

V. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

A. Limited Sample Size –

The survey conducted for this study included participants from 10 universities, which may not fully represent the diverse student population across various campuses. Future research could involve a larger and more diverse sample to obtain a more comprehensive understanding of student behavior and preferences.

B. Generalizability —

As UniSync has not been officially launched yet, the survey responses and findings are based on hypothetical interest and perceptions. Future studies could evaluate the actual usage and impact of the platform once it is fully operational.

C. Long-term Sustainability –

Although the study indicates potential benefits of UniSync in waste reduction and affordability “Fig. 7”, long-term sustainability “Fig. 6” of the platform and its scalability need to be further examined. Future research could explore the platform's longevity, user engagement, and strategies to ensure its continuous operation. In conclusion, the findings of this study highlight the positive user behavior and interest in peer-to-peer trading platforms like UniSync. The platform shows potential for reducing waste and improving affordability for students. However, further research is needed to address limitations, assess long-term sustainability, and explore additional areas of impact. These insights can guide the future development and implementation of UniSync and similar platforms to enhance their effectiveness in promoting sustainability and affordability on university campuses.

How likely are you to see a platform like UniSync to buy or sell textbooks and stationary ?

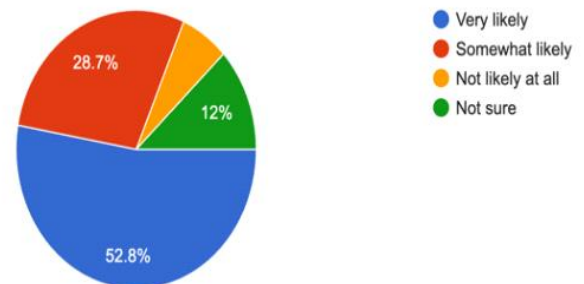


Fig. 7. Affordability Survey

VI. CONCLUSION

Through an extensive literature review and empirical study, this research paper delves into the factors influencing Customer Loyalty (CL) [5] within online marketplaces like UniSync. It scrutinizes how anticipated consumer benefits, including enjoyable experiences, monetary incentives, and loyalty programs, shape customer loyalty. To foster customer loyalty, UniSync ought to concentrate on delivering these benefits to meet customer expectations, thereby encouraging repeat purchases and nurturing long-term loyalty. Furthermore, these findings furnish valuable insights for other online marketplaces striving to bolster customer loyalty. Additionally, the study outcomes furnish theoretical and managerial guidance for online marketplaces akin to UniSync. By discerning the factors underpinning customer loyalty, UniSync can formulate strategies that elevate customer experiences, spur repeat purchases, and foster enduring loyalty. Moreover, by offering environmentally friendly and socially responsible benefits, UniSync can appeal to environmentally conscious consumers and contribute to societal betterment.



Furthermore, the research underscores the significance of customer loyalty within sustainable and Eco-conscious marketplaces. UniSync stands to forge robust connections with customers by furnishing benefits aligned with environmental sustainability and social responsibility. This approach not only cultivates loyal customers but also champions sustainability efforts, contributing to a greener world.

By prioritizing sustainability and ethical principles, UniSync can allure consumers who espouse these values, potentially augmenting sales and profitability while championing global betterment. Overall, UniSync holds the potential to effect positive change by championing sustainability and ethical standards within online marketplaces.

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